



DIVING PENGUINS

Small Antarctic penguins such as chinstrap and Adélie penguins also feed mainly on krill, chasing after them and catching them one by one in their sharp bills. The bigger king and emperor penguins catch fish and squid, sometimes diving to immense depths to find them. The emperor penguin may dive to a depth of 1,640 ft (500 m) or more, and stay underwater for up to 18 minutes before returning to the surface for air.



▲ DOWNY CHICKS

The dark, downy Adélie chicks grow fast, and are soon almost as big as their black-and-white parents. After about eight weeks, their soft downy feathers are replaced by waterproof feathers, enabling them to hunt for food on their own.

ROCKY NURSERIES

Adélie penguins breed on the shores of Antarctica itself, further south than any other penguins. They wait until the relative warmth of summer has melted the snow to expose some bare rock on the coast, then form big breeding colonies with hundreds or even thousands of mated pairs. Each pair makes a nest of stones, and they take turns to incubate their two eggs until the chicks hatch.



HUDDLING EMPERORS

Most Antarctic penguins nest on rocky shores in summer. But emperor penguins are bigger and take longer to grow up, so the summer is not long enough for them to both incubate their eggs and rear their chicks. Instead, they start breeding on the sea ice the previous winter, huddling together to keep out the bitter chill. The eggs hatch in spring, so the chicks are able to develop through the summer before the winter closes in again.

▲ WINTER VIGIL

Emperor penguins lay their eggs in autumn. They are incubated by the males throughout the bone-chilling Antarctic winter, while the females feed at sea. Each male supports his egg on his big black feet to keep it off the ice and stop it from freezing solid.